

ANGEL ACTION · ALLERGY

Anaphylaxis

Anaphylaxis is a life-threatening allergic reaction. Lay the person flat, give adrenaline (EpiPen) immediately, call 000, and give a second dose after 5 minutes if there is no improvement.

Recognise anaphylaxis

Any **one** of these after exposure to an allergen is anaphylaxis:

- Difficult or noisy breathing
- Swelling of the tongue
- Swelling or tightness in the throat
- Difficulty talking and/or hoarse voice
- Wheeze or persistent cough
- Persistent dizziness or collapse
- Pale and floppy (young children)

Mild symptoms may include hives, swelling of lips and eyes, abdominal pain or vomiting. These can rapidly progress.

What to do

1. **Lay the person flat.** Do NOT let them stand or walk — this can cause sudden death. If breathing is hard, allow them to sit with legs out, but never stand.
2. **Give adrenaline** with an autoinjector (EpiPen) into the outer mid-thigh — through clothing is fine. Hold for **3 seconds**.
3. **Call 000.**
4. After 5 minutes, if there is no improvement, **give a second dose** if available.
5. If the person becomes unresponsive and is not breathing normally, start **CPR**.
6. If they have asthma symptoms as well, give adrenaline first, then a **blue asthma reliever**.

Using an EpiPen

1. Form a fist around the EpiPen — **blue to the sky, orange to the thigh**.
2. Pull off the blue safety cap.
3. Place the orange end firmly against the outer mid-thigh and push until it clicks.
4. Hold for 3 seconds.
5. Massage the area for 10 seconds.
6. Note the time so you know when to give the second dose.

Adapted from Australian First Aid 5th Edition. Get the full guide and live CPR metronome at firstaidangel.org.